NOSTRIAN CONQUEST

Quick Start Player's Guide

Version 1.0.0-beta.3 • Revision date: October 11, 2026

---

1. Your First Year

Expand from one world, build your economy, and defeat your rivals. The game ends when one empire becomes Emperor and no serious contender remains.

You issue orders between maintenance runs. There is no End Turn button. Maintenance resolves everyone's orders and advances the year. Ask your sysop for the schedule. Builds and the economy run first; movement and combat then unfold over 52 internal weeks. `Stardate 14/3002` means week 14 of year 3002.

1.1. What You Start With

A standard new empire has one homeworld at Production 100, a treasury of 35 points, 10 armies, and 4 ground batteries. It also has four fleets:

- **Fleets 1 and 2:** each has `CA1 ETAC1` — a cruiser and a reusable colony ship.
- **Fleets 3 and 4:** each has `DD1` — a destroyer for early exploration and defense.

An ETAC does not carry an army. It claims unowned worlds with **Colonize**, mission 12. Troop transports (`TT`) carry armies for conquest. Check your own reports and fleet list; an existing campaign may differ from this opening.

1.2. First-Turn Checklist

1. **Read your reports.** From the main menu, press `G`, then `R` for the Inbox. It has Reports, Messages, and Sent folders. Return with `Q`.
2. **Inspect your worlds.** Main-menu `P` opens Planet Command. `T` sets **one tax rate for your entire empire**. Around 50–65% is a useful opening range: lower taxes favor growth; higher taxes collect more now. Above 65%, production suffers a penalty.
3. **Queue useful builds.** In Planet Command, `B` opens Build Commands; `S` specifies orders. A cruiser costs 15 points, a destroyer 5, and an ETAC 20. Spend for your plan; your homeworld already has defenses. Builds complete during maintenance. Commission finished ships from stardock with Planet Command `C` or `M` before using them.
4. **Explore and colonize.** Main-menu `F` opens Fleet Command. Use `O` to assign orders. Send a destroyer on **View**, mission 9, to inspect a nearby world. Send a cruiser-and-ETAC fleet on **Colonize**, mission 12, to an unowned world. Do not use an invasion order to found a colony. Scout missions 10 and 11 require a Scout (`SC`), not a destroyer.
5. **Check travel time, then log off.** Use the fleet ETA command (`E`) and include system-entry time for a world mission. Check targets and standing orders. Return to the main menu and press `Q` when finished.

> **REMEMBER:** Colonization can take more than one year. The ETAC survives, so send it to another unowned world after the colony is established. Review the results after every maintenance.

2. Ships, Travel, and Growth

2.1. Know Your Ships

Code	Cost	Speed	Role
DD	5	6	Destroyer: fast combat ship and raider.
CA	15	5	Cruiser: balanced fighter and escort.
BB	45	4	Battleship: heavy firepower and durability.
SC	15	6	Scout: unarmed reconnaissance ship.
TT	5	5	Troop transport: carries one army; built empty.
ETAC	20	3	Reusable colony ship; cannot invade.
SB	50	1	Starbase: separate unit, with orbital defense and economic benefits.

Speed is sectors per year. A fleet travels at its slowest ship's speed. Leaving orbit costs one sector of movement, and entering a destination's orbit costs another. Check ETA rather than assuming a nearby world is one turn away.

2.2. Read the Ship Notation

- `CA12` means twelve cruisers, none crippled.
- `CA12!3` means twelve cruisers in all, three crippled.
- `TT*4!1` means four loaded transports, one crippled. `TT2` means two empty transports.
- A trailing `+` in a narrow list means more ships; Review shows the full fleet.

The legend is `! = crippled; * = loaded`.

Detach and Transfer: enter a ship code such as `CA`, then a quantity. `3` selects three ships, healthy first. `3!` selects exactly three crippled ships. These are two prompts: do not enter `CA3!` as one command. Check the staged ships before confirming.

2.3. Recovery Is Automatic

Crippled ships fight at half strength but keep their speed. A ship crippled this year stays damaged through the next two years and is whole for the year after that. No repair order or payment is needed. Resting for a full year at your own world beside your own starbase lets older cripples recover a year sooner; newly damaged ships do not get that bonus in their damage year.

2.4. Grow Before You Fight

New colonies start at Production 3 and begin growing and earning revenue the following maintenance. Lowering taxes helps them develop, but lowers the rate on your homeworld too. Tax changes do not change a world's Potential Production.

A commissioned starbase at rest in orbit boosts growth at taxes below 65% and lets the world spend up to five times its production from saved treasury. More bases add defense, not more economic bonuses. Armies cost 2 points and batteries 20. They deploy to the surface when their builds complete, not when you place the order.

3. Combat and Your Next Login

3.1. Choose Your Risks

ROE (Rules of Engagement) runs from 0 to 10. Set it with Fleet Command `C`. ROE 0 never volunteers to attack; ROE 6 requires at least equal attack strength; ROE 10 accepts any odds. The comparison uses participating sides' attack strength, including damaged ships at their reduced strength, rather than ship counts.

A fleet that is attacked must fight one exchange. After each exchange, its ROE decides whether it stays. Fleets without warships try to escape. Faster enemies can catch a retreat, so low ROE is not a promise of safety. Escorts protect auxiliaries from ordinary fire while the combat line holds, but critical hits can reach past it.

Scout before assaulting. Enemy starbases and defending fleets in orbit must be dealt with before a planetary strike. Then choose the mission:

- **Bombard (6):** repeated attacks that can destroy batteries, docked ships, armies, goods, and production. It continues each year until you change orders.
- **Invade (7):** suppress batteries, soften the garrison, then land armies from loaded transports. Surviving batteries block the landing. Industry and goods are preserved.
- **Blitz (8):** land sooner with brief cover fire. Surviving batteries fire on your transports. Industry is preserved, and surviving batteries become yours if you capture the world.

Defending armies fire first in each ground round. Equal numbers are a poor gamble; bring a margin. Invade and Blitz finish on Hold after the assault. A captured world earns no revenue for the next two maintenance turns. Conquest takes both ships and time.

3.2. Find the Right Menu

Keys depend on the menu. These paths start at the **main menu**; press `Q` to back out of a submenu first.

Keys	Action
`P`, then `T`	Set the empire-wide tax rate.
`P`, then `B`	Build ships and defenses.
`F`, then `O`	Assign a fleet mission.
`F`, then `C`	Change fleet ROE, ID, or speed.
`G`, then `R`	Review the Inbox: Reports, Messages, Sent.
`G`, then `C`	Send a message to another empire.
`G`, then `M`	Open the galaxy map.
`G`, then `E`	Declare or list enemies.
`V`	View a partial map.
`B` or `D`	Brief or detailed empire report.
`H` or `?`	Help for the current screen.
`Q`	Leave a submenu; from the main menu, quit.

At your next login, read the reports, commission completed ships, and check fleets that finished their missions. Sent shows queued messages until maintenance delivers them. General Command `D` clears reports from your view; it does not erase the game's stored history.

For the full rules and tables, read **nc_player_manual.pdf**, shipped beside this guide.

© 2026 Mason A. Green. New text and layout licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.